

Laston Petro Manja

Economics Ph.D. Candidate, University of Michigan

Lecturer in Economics, University of Malawi

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EDUCATION

- 2023 – Ph.D. in Economics, University of Michigan, Ann Arbor, MI.
Research fields: Development Economics, Labor Economics
- 2016 – 2018 M.A. in Economics, University of Malawi, Zomba, Malawi
- 2011 – 2015 Bachelor of Social Science (Economics), University of Malawi, Zomba, Malawi

RELEVANT WORK EXPERIENCE

- 2020 – Lecturer in Economics, Department of Economics, University of Malawi
- 2021 – 2023 Research Assistant, University of Michigan
- 2019 – 2020 Education Analyst Consultant, The World Bank
- 2019 – 2020 Finance, Competitiveness, and Innovation Consultant, The World Bank
- 2018 – 2020 Macroeconomics, Trade, and Investment Consultant, The World Bank
- 2018 – 2019 Research and Teaching Assistant, University of Malawi
- 2016 – 2018 Part-time Lecturer, University of Malawi

RESEARCH FIELDS

Development Economics; Labor Economics; Education; Public Finance; Political Economy; African Economic Development

SELECTED RESEARCH IN PROGRESS

1. **Colonizer Identity and Economic Development: Evidence from the “Scramble for Africa”**, with Thomas Lloyd.
2. **School Finance, Administrative Capacity, and Resilience in Malawi**. Third-year paper.

SELECTED PEER-REVIEWED PRE-PH.D. JOURNAL ARTICLES

1. Manja, L. P., Zingwe, D. E., & Kamangila, A. E. (2025). **Smallholder farming commercialization and food security in Malawi: Do land rights and intrahousehold bargaining power matter?** *Agriculture & Food Security*, 14, 2.
2. Tembo, D., Manja, L. P., & Joshua, M. K. (2025). **Faith and food in rural Malawi: An investigation into the sociocultural determinants of household food security**. *Food, Culture & Society*, 28(4), 1055–1083.
3. Manja, L. P., & Badjie, I. A. (2025). **Does household welfare change with finance access? The case of women and the youth in The Gambia**. *Review of Development Economics*, 29(1), 64–104.
4. Chirwa, G. C., Manja, L. P., Chasukwa, M., Gunde, A., Dulani, B., Kayuni, H., & Chinsinga, B. (2023). **Assessing the relationship between digital divide and citizens’ political participation in Africa**. *Development Southern Africa*, 40(6), 1258–1276.
5. Zingwe, D. E., Banda, A. E., & Manja, L. P. (2023). **The effects of remittances on household food nutrition security in the context of multiple shocks in Malawi**. *Cogent Food & Agriculture*, 9(1).
6. Salima, W., Manja, L. P., Chiwaula, L. S., & Chirwa, G. C. (2023). **The impact of credit access on household food security in Malawi**. *Journal of Agriculture and Food Research*, 11, 100490.
7. Manja, L. P., & Badjie, I. A. (2022). **The welfare effects of formal and informal financial access in The Gambia: A comparative assessment**. *SAGE Open*, 12(1).
8. Manja, L. P., Silumbu, E. B. D., & Chaweza, R. D. C. (2022). **Determinants of demand for international reserves in the SADC region**. *African Review of Economics and Finance*, 1–28.
9. Kambewa, P., Khangamwa, L., Masanjala, W., Chaweza, R., & Manja, L. P. (2022). The impact of ill-health on welfare of rural agricultural households of Teuka Village in Zomba District, Malawi: An application of the individual household modelling approach. *Malawi Journal of Economics*, 3(1), 1–13.

10. Zingwe, D. E., Manja, L. P., & Chirwa, E. W. (2021). **The effects of engendered intra-household power dynamics on household food security and nutrition in Malawi.** *Journal of Gender Studies*.
11. Al-Hanawi, M. K., Chirwa, G. C., Kamninga, T. M., & Manja, L. P. (2020). **Effects of financial inclusion on access to emergency funds for healthcare in the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia.** *Journal of Multidisciplinary Healthcare*, 13, 1157–1167.

PRE-PH.D. WORKING PAPERS

1. Manja, L. P. (2022). **Payment Delays for Cash Transfers: The Role of Subsistence Constraints.** University of Michigan African Presidential Scholars Fellowship Working Paper.
2. Manja, L. P., & Badjie, I. A. (2022). **The Impacts of Access to Finance on Household Welfare: A Mixed Methods Approach for Women and the Youth in The Gambia.** African Economic Research Consortium Working Paper.

SELECTED CO-AUTHORED REPORTS

1. World Bank. (2019). **Malawi Economic Monitor, December 2019: Strengthening Human Capital Through Nutrition.** Lilongwe, Malawi: World Bank.
2. World Bank. (2019). **Malawi Economic Monitor, June 2019: Charting a New Course.** Lilongwe, Malawi: World Bank.
3. World Bank. (2018). **Malawi Economic Monitor, November 2018: Investing in Girls' Education.** Washington, DC: World Bank.

BOOK CHAPTER

1. Mwale, M. L., Chirwa, G. C., Kamninga, T. M., & Manja, L. P. (2021). **Trust in Election Management Bodies, Participation in Demonstrations and Willingness to Pay Taxes: Evidence from Malawi.** In K. Ross, A. L. Chiweza, & W. O. Mulwafu (Eds.), *Beyond Impunity: New Directions for Governance in Malawi* (pp. 97–114).

TEACHING

University of Michigan

Winter 2026	Principles of Macroeconomics (ECON 102), Head Graduate Student Instructor (GSI)
Fall 2025	Principles of Macroeconomics (ECON 102), Graduate Student Instructor (GSI)
Winter 2025	Principles of Microeconomics (ECON 101), Graduate Student Instructor (GSI)
Fall 2024	Principles of Macroeconomics (ECON 102), Graduate Student Instructor (GSI)

University of Malawi (Undergraduate and Masters Lecturer)

2021 – 2023	Advanced Macroeconomics (ECO 620)
2020 – 2022	Monetary Economics (ECO 322)
2021 – 2022	Labor Economics (ECO 413)
2021 – 2022	The Malawi Economy (ECO 224)
2022	Development Economics (DEC 313)
2022	Monitoring and Evaluation (DEC 423)
2021	History of Economic Thought (ECO 214)

RESEARCH GRANTS

2026	Rackham Graduate Student Research Grant, University of Michigan
2026	Co-Grantee, U-M ISR Marshall Weinberg Fellowship in Population, Development and Climate Change
2026	Co-Grantee, U-M African Studies Center Support for Student Research and Internships in Africa
2021	Co-Grantee, AERC “Inclusive Finance for Fragile and Post-Conflict States in Africa” Project
2019	Co-Grantee, IFPRI “Enhancing the Impact of Agricultural Extension in Malawi” Project
2019	Co-Grantee, AERC AFPON Project

FELLOWSHIPS, AWARDS, AND SCHOLARSHIPS

- 2022 University of Michigan African Presidential Scholars Program
- 2018 World Bank Internship, awarded to top graduate student from the University of Malawi
- 2016 AERC-CMAP Joint Facility for Electives Scholarship, Kenyan School of Monetary Studies
- 2011–2015 University of Malawi Dean’s List Awards; Government of Malawi National Merit Scholarship

SEMINAR AND CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

- 2026 Midwest International Economic Development Conference (MWIEDC), Madison, WI.
- 2026 Michigan Development Economics Conference (MDev), Ann Arbor, MI.
- 2023 AERC-IDRC Dissemination Workshop on “Inclusive Finance for Fragile and Post-Conflict Contexts in Africa,” Banjul, The Gambia.
- 2020 Manja, L. P., & Silumbu, E. B. D. **The Comparative Potential Growth-Enhancing Effects of the AfCFTA and COMESA Trade Regimes**. Seventh COMESA Annual Research Forum, Virtual, October 19–21. Published in *COMESA Key Issues in Regional Integration*, Vol. 9.
- 2019 AERC Workshop on “Agricultural and Food Policy Analysis for Nutrition Outcomes,” Nairobi, Kenya.

SERVICE

- 2026 – Co-President, African Graduate Student Association (AGSA), University of Michigan
- 2025 – 2026 Treasurer, African Graduate Student Association (AGSA), University of Michigan
- 2025 – 2026 Co-organizer of the Development Workshop (DevWorkshop) seminar in the Department of Economics, University of Michigan
- 2020 – Student mentorship at the University of Malawi
- 2017 Co-started Chirimba Youth Organization to address drug and substance abuse and support school dropouts’ return to school
- 2015 Electoral Commissioner for University of Malawi student leader elections

SKILLS, LANGUAGES, AND CITIZENSHIP

- Statistical: Stata, R, Julia, Python, EViews, NVivo, CPro, SPSS
- Administrative: L^AT_EX, JabRef, Git, Microsoft Office Suite, project management, project administration
- Survey Design: SurveyCTO, ODK, World Bank CAPI/CAWI
- Research: Proposal writing, data collection, data analysis, report writing, monitoring and evaluation
- Languages: English (fluent); Chichewa (native)
- Citizenship: Malawian.